Mirrors and Windows

Civic Skill: Difference | EYLF: EYLF Outcome 1 (Identity) & Outcome 2 (Community) | Duration: 20–30 minutes | Age: 4–6 years

LEARNING INTENTION

Children will use literature to recognise both themselves and unfamiliar others, building the habit of reading stories as a way of understanding people different from themselves.

SUCCESS CRITERIA

- I can find something in a story that is like my own life (a mirror).
- I can find something in a story that is different from my life but real for someone else (a window).
- I can be curious about the window — asking 'what is their life like?' rather than 'that's strange'.

MATERIALS

- Picture books featuring characters whose family, culture, ability, or experience differs from the majority of the group: suggestions include 'Last Stop on Market Street' by Matt de la Peña, 'The Name Jar' by Yangsook Choi, 'Eyes That Kiss in the Corners' by Joanna Ho
- Two large frames made of cardboard: one labelled 'MIRROR' and one labelled 'WINDOW'
- Sticky notes for responses

ACTIVITY STEPS

1. INTRODUCE THE CONCEPT (5 min): Hold up the two cardboard frames. 'A mirror shows you yourself. A window shows you something new. Books can be both — and today we're going to look for each one.'

2. READ ALOUD (10 min): Read the chosen book slowly. Pause twice: once in the middle and once at the end. At each pause: 'Is this a mirror moment — something that felt like your life? Or a window moment — something you've never seen before but feels real for someone?'

3. POST-ITS ON FRAMES (5 min): Children draw or dictate one mirror and one window onto sticky notes. Place them on the frames. Educator reads some aloud.

4. DISCUSSION (5 min): 'Did anyone have a window moment that made them want to know more? What would you ask the character if they were here?' Focus curiosity outward rather than comparison.

5. BOOK DISPLAY: Begin a classroom display of 'mirrors and windows' — books that show us ourselves and show us others. Children can suggest additions.

EXTENSIONS

- Invite children to bring a book from home that shows their family or community
- Create a reading list that deliberately includes books featuring First Nations Australian children, children with disability, diverse family structures
- Older children: write or draw a story from the perspective of a character whose life is different from theirs

ASSESSMENT

- Sticky note contributions: are they genuine reflections or surface-level observations?
- Note children who consistently identify only mirrors — they may need more scaffolding to engage with windows
- Learning story: document the window moment that generated the most curiosity or surprise

EDUCATOR REFLECTION QUESTIONS

- Were there scenarios where children disagreed with your framing of fairness? What does that reveal?
- How do you model speaking up when you see unfairness in front of children?
- Which children in your group may be experiencing unfairness that this lesson could be inviting them to name?

EYLF LINKS

This lesson directly supports EYLF Outcome 2 (Community) & Outcome 3 (Wellbeing). Educators should record observations using anecdotal notes, photographs, or learning stories focused on children's language, body responses, and social interactions during the session.